

Hope Gets a NUMBER

A non-profit initiative takes emergency care to new places as more and more states seek to adopt the 108 service that offers immediate medical assistance

By Amarnath K. Menon

What's 108? Ask this question in Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat and Uttarakhand and the response is immediate—it's the free ambulance service. The toll-free 108, accessible from all networks, landlines as well as cellular, has emerged as a popular number for medical, police or fire emergencies. It has its share of false alarms too, yet genuine calls are helping save many lives as victims are rushed to a nearest hospital within the first hour of an accident.

That there is a need for the service cannot be disputed. At least four of every five deaths take place in the first hour of admission to hospital. A McKinsey study reveals that India witnesses three lakh emergencies daily. These include medical crises (2.4 million health-related deaths), traffic accidents (one lakh deaths a year), deaths due to drowning and poisoning (65 a day) and suicides (312 a day). There are emergencies arising from fire (52 deaths a day), and from crimes like theft, murder (30,000 a year) and rape (15,000 reported incidents a year). With a little over 1.5 million hospital beds—a ratio of less than 1.5 beds for 1,000 people—and less than one physician for 1,000 people, there simply are not enough resources to cater to emergencies.

A PATIENT BEING
SHIFTED INTO AN EMRI
VAN IN HYDERABAD

Health-related emergencies, increasing road accidents and crime have made the 108 service vital in the states it operates in

Explains Venkat Chengavalli, CEO of the not-for-profit Emergency Management and Research Institute (EMRI), the organisation behind 108, "Changing lifestyles, increasing road accidents and crimes, persistently high rates of birth and fire-related emergencies demand integration of multiple agencies to provide quick emergency response." EMRI was founded by Satyam Computer Services Chairman B. Ramalinga Raju on a public-private partnership model and it retains Satyam as a strategic partner. It has also entered into a similar alliance with the National Emergency Number Association, USA.

